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The impact of the OECD on education worldwide

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Over the past few decades, the Organization for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) has become one of the most unique, active and influential players in the global arena. Though established originally for economic and development sector, it has been posing both extensive and inclusive impact on education worldwide. Being the "new kids strolling through the global garden", international agencies are active in transferring educational knowledge in the context of globalization (Beech, 2009). As one of the "kids", the OECD has been playing an irreplaceable role in shaping educational policies whether as a platform for the promotion of the "best practice" or as a deadlock of "isomorphism". However, relatively little attention has been paid to the OECD's particular influence compared with the other two impactful international organizations, UNESCO and the World Bank. Therefore, the publication of this volume seems to be both timely and necessary.

Divided into three parts, this volume consists of ten individual chapters written or co-worked by various researchers with different focuses. Part I includes three chapters concerning the OECD's history and context. Beginning with an example of France, the first chapter gives a historical review of the development of PISA in France and analyzes the reasons why it took France so long to fully recognize the value of PISA. The author argues that the main reason for such delay is the incompatibility of the competence-based PISA orientation with the academic tradition in French school systems. The author also recognizes PISA can play a positive role in redesigning French education programs. In the next chapter, PISA is also used as a meaningful tool to examine how national trends in STEM occupational experiences among 15-year-olds changed between PISA 2000 and PISA 2006 at the country level after controlling for student and school characteristics. The study found that national trends in STEM-related occupational expectations differed across STEM subfields, student gender and performance level, all of which can be informative for policymakers to formulate STEM-related educational policies. Yet the third chapter takes a critical perspective based on a fine-grained analysis of the documents related to TALIS and semi-structured individuals interviews with five staff members of the OECD. The authors analyse the nature and foundations of teaching orientations transmitted by the OECD through its discourse and found that there is a problematic and paradoxical pedagogical position in the OECD. The teaching orientations are not founded on the evidence-based policy which it uses as the main tool for decision-making, rather, it is the "socio-constructivist" practices that is valued.

Part II consists of four chapters focusing on the current educational impact of the OECD, more concretely, the impact on school leaders, the public, teachers and the school as a whole. In *School Leadership for Equity*, Beatriz Pont tries to explore the policies and practices that can develop and support school leaders to ensure equity and quality across school systems, especially in disadvantaged schools. In contribution to improve educational outcomes of the more disadvantaged groups, she recommends that policy-makers invest more to support the "actors of reforms", the

school leaders, practice towards equity. The focus is changed to the public in the following chapter *Big Comparisons, Little Knowledge* by Oren Pizmony-Levy. It is pointed out that though the public release of PISA results has generated huge attention of policymakers when designing and launching educational reforms, little is understood about the extent to which the public knows about PISA results. Under such context, the author uses survey data from the United States and Israel, both of which have long participation records not only in PISA but also in other ILSA, to examine the public knowledge of and views towards PISA. Interestingly, despite the fact that the general public opinions on PISA results in both countries seem to be misinformed by some factors like oversimplified yet attention-grabbing media coverage, OECD was successful in generating public support for the use of PISA to assess student performance. In *The OECD Diffusion Mechanisms and Its Link with Teacher Policy Worldwide*, another vital actor in education, teachers, is targeted. The chapter presents a theoretical and historical overview of the OECD educational policy diffusion mechanisms focusing on the its policy message on teachers, and argues that the OECD's initial perspective of human capital theory has incorporated with the notion of professional capital, which is clear in the use of autonomy, management, and networking as the main domains in conceptualizing teacher professionalism. In the last chapter of this part, how schools and schooling systems are influenced by the OECD is analysed. The targeted school-level data and comparisons provided by PISA for Schools limit the mediation by national and/or subnational politics thus enabling the OECD to influence upon schools and local educators. Through spatial relations, the quantitative and comparative performance data situate culturally different and geographically distant schooling systems and schools within a commensurate education field, where the OECD successfully effects school-level reforms and practices its epistemological governance of education. However, the author argues that the comparisons in PISA for Schools also lead to oversimplification of complex situations by positioning a school as a decontextualized, acultural and ahistorical entity.

Part III takes a broad view of OECD's impact on national education systems. Through a comparative analysis of Japan and Norway, Hitoshi Sato examines the structure of PISA penetration into education policy, with a particular focus on national curriculum. Different from the previous study which emphasize the character of PISA result as a norm, this chapter focuses on PISA as a norm of educational contents. By describing the background of PISA acceptance and clarifying the character and position of national curriculum in both two countries, how PISA penetrates into educational policy is clearly demonstrated. Similarities are concluded by comparison: in the context of "PISA shock" experienced by both countries, PISA penetrated into the existing educational goals or subjects of the national curriculum as a norm of educational contents in view of the structure of the educational system. The following chapter takes South Korea as a specific example to illustrate how PISA exerts its educational impact from the aspects of education policy, national curriculum reform and examination systems. Based on the travelling theory and the idea of territorialization, PISA is regarded as a travelling educational event with specific epistemologies of comparison and numbers, which re-territorializes the space of education in Korea. Through such analysis, this chapter problematizes the present-day OECD educational policy and its ways of telling educational truths by statistical data. Furthermore, the author argues that the impact of the OECD is not a unidirectional influence as transplanting but multidirectional changes by localizing its global discourse with individual context. In closing this volume, the final chapter, *Looking back towards the Future: Reflecting on the OECD's Global Educational Influence*, critically summarizes the perspectives and key findings presented in the previous chapters, and further explores those issues in the context of wider literature on global education policy. Following a brief historical review of the context where the OECD developed as a global education policy actor, the author collectively raises several important theoretical questions about the role of the OECD as global governor, which dealing with the role of states and spatialities in the global knowledge society, the paradox of the OECD's accountability and its empirically backed, evidence-based educational policy on governing teacher's work, and its epistemological governance by international assessments such as PISA and TALIS.

Comprehensive and well organized, the volume describes, analyzes and discusses the OECD's impact on education worldwide by looking at the past, the present and the future of the OECD's work. Surely it is worth the attention of primarily policymakers and global education researchers. The major findings and results of this volume also provides implications for the Asia and Pacific region specifically. Firstly, although most countries in this region are not the member of OECD, this fact does not hinder a new reality that OECD is an emerging global agency of educational governance. It reminds us that local educational reform cannot be separated from the global context which is featured by a "post-national" policy environment and internationalization of educational policies. Secondly, some experiences for the successful school education identified by this volume, such as the methodology of test, the key role of school leadership and quality of teachers, can be considered as references for this region as well. The last but not least, this volume expresses concerns on this evidence-based regime governance. Actually, this is particularly the warning case for some transition countries in this region which overvalue and heavily rely on the "evidence" just like numbers, data and indictors in the current "era of quantitative enthusiasm".

Reference

Beech, J. (2009). Who is strolling through the global garden? International agencies and educational transfer. In R. Cowen & A.M. Kazamias (Eds.), *International handbook of comparative education* (pp. 342). London: Springer.

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